MAINTAINING BRITISH NAVAL POWER

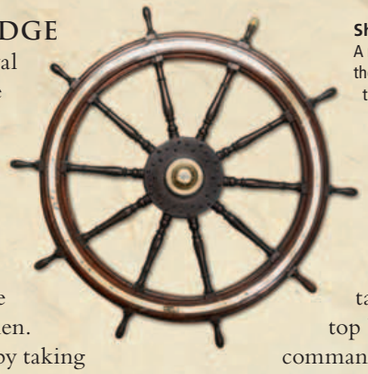


Capture of Porto Bello
A typical exploit of the Royal Navy that caught the imagination of the British public was the capture of Porto Bello on the Isthmus of Panama. Vice Admiral Vernon had claimed in the House of Commons that he could take the Spanish port with just six ships of the line. A few months later in November 1739 he duly made good his boast.

BY THE START of the 18th century, Britain had established itself as the world's dominant naval power. But maintaining this status was at times a close-run thing. France and Spain pushed Britain hard, especially when they fought together. The French in particular had the potential to challenge British naval supremacy, although they were usually distracted by land wars in Europe. The responsibilities the Royal Navy had to shoulder in war—defense of overseas colonies, protection of merchant shipping, prevention of an invasion of the British Isles—meant resources were thinly spread. The British rarely fought battles with any great numerical advantage, but in the last resort no one could match them for bold aggressive leadership allied to seamanship of a high order.

PRACTICAL KNOWLEDGE

The administration of the Royal Navy was efficient for the time but the system of recruitment was far from ideal. The use of press-gangs to transfer seamen from merchant ships in time of war was clumsy and haphazard compared with the French system of "classes"—the conscription of registered seamen. The training of British officers by taking young boys on board as midshipmen meant their formal education was minimal, whereas the French developed a body of well-educated naval officers with a scientific knowledge of navigation and gunnery. Yet the British officers' practical knowledge of the sea was incomparable.

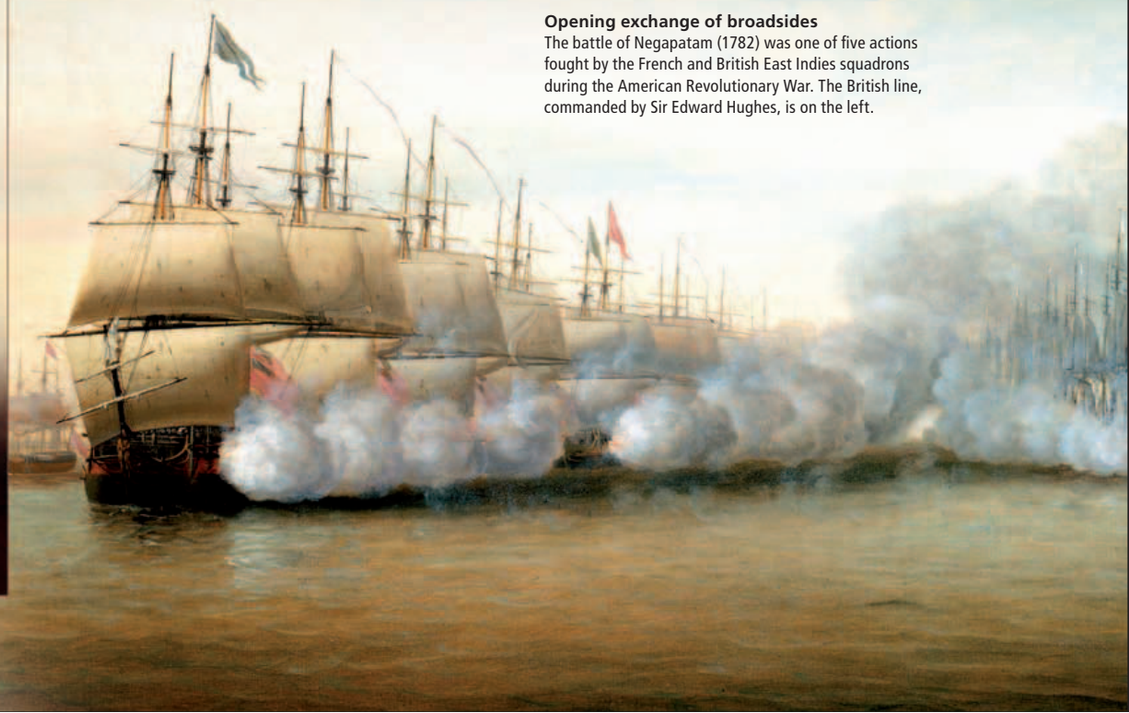


Ship's steering wheel
A major innovation of the late 17th century was the ship's wheel, which allowed the helmsman to stand on the quarterdeck and control the tiller via a system of ropes and pulleys.

Although promotion in the Royal Navy was governed by a mix of personal patronage and strict seniority, men of talent were able to rise to the top by merit—outstanding commanders such as Edward Hawke, Edward Boscawen, and George Rodney.

MAJOR WARS

Between the death of French King Louis XIV in 1715 and the outbreak of the French Revolution in 1789, Britain and France fought



Opening exchange of broadsides
The battle of Negapatam (1782) was one of five actions fought by the French and British East Indies squadrons during the American Revolutionary War. The British line, commanded by Sir Edward Hughes, is on the left.

1719–1792

GEORGE RODNEY

BRITISH ADMIRAL

The son of a marine officer, George Rodney joined the navy aged 13 and saw action as a captain under Admiral Hawke at Cape Finisterre in 1747. Rodney distinguished himself during the Seven Years War, especially in the capture of Martinique in 1762. Despite being made Rear Admiral of Great Britain, in the subsequent peace he fell heavily into debt and fled to France to escape his creditors. He was able to return to fight in the American Revolutionary War only because a French aristocrat settled his debts. Although aging and ill, he was appointed to command the West Indies squadron. Victories over the Spanish at Cape St Vincent in 1780 and the French at the Saints in 1782, both displaying aggressive, unorthodox tactics, crowned his career.

